GRAND-CHUKUCHUKU

Pilot v2 — THE MAN WHO NEVER RAN

Target edit: 5:00 · vertical 9:16 · original adult animated thriller. Performed runtime requires an animatic.

Author: Based on the life of Nkeh Nkengzincho (Zino).

Draft: 30 October 2026. All dialogue and individual actions below are proposed dramatization.

Logline

A boy invents a man who never runs. When a real crowd turns violent, he must choose between the hero he performs and the friends he can actually protect.

ACT I — THE STORY HE TELLS | 0:00–1:34

EXT. FIANGO COMPOUND — WELL — NIGHT | 0:00–0:12

Fresh drinking water leaks from Zino's cupped hands. He has lifted it from a drawn bucket beside the well, but cannot steady it long enough to bring it to his mouth. This is not washing into the communal water supply. The bucket must be established in the wider animation layout. The cuff is a schoolboy's; the hands are older than those we are about to meet. A neighbour's radio is too far away to understand.

MOTHER (O.S., English): What happened?

Zino looks up. Nothing comes. Cut on a water drop before he can answer.

EXT. FIANGO ROAD / COMPOUND — AFTERNOON | 0:12–0:50

CARD: FOUR YEARS EARLIER.

The drop becomes a football thump. A scuffed ball races between a pair of slippers and grazes the outside one. Ten-year-old ZINO has already raised his arms.

GIDEON: Outside.

ZINO: Na goal.

Luc shakes his head. Gideon points at the disturbed slipper. Zino notices two younger listeners near the well. He changes the audience instead of the score.

ZINO: Grand-Chukuchuku score from worse side.

His raised finger becomes the movement that brings GRAND-CHUKUCHUKU into an invented golden version of the same compound. Adult, navy suit, open white collar, brown shoes: composed on the ordinary roofline. He walks toward the roar of Zino's imagined football spectators. He does not fly, fight or enter reality.

ZINO (V.O.): Grand-Chukuchuku no ever run.

MOTHER (O.S., English): Zino. The water.

The gold switches off. The same boy has a bucket to carry. A quick glance at his friends: tomorrow he can still insist that the ball was in.

INT./EXT. PROFESSIONAL SCHOOL — EVENING | 0:50–1:34

CARD: FOUR YEARS LATER — EARLIER THAT EVENING.

A high view establishes the geography: the vocational campus, the gate, the road, the compound opposite. Practical classroom light holds back the night. Inside, construction and electrical diagrams remain on the board. Some students work alone; others share pages. Conversation in the corridor competes with pencil scratches.

Zino, now approximately fourteen, points at one step in Luc's maths problem. He gives Luc the pencil back.

ZINO: You solve am. I only show you road.

Gideon moves his closed camera bag away from a passing elbow. A page in his book holds proposed booking notes, not a readable real client name.

GIDEON: You people finish, find me one customer.

Luc nods to a student who has stopped to listen beside his small Bible. A sincere exchange starts; Zino quietly slides the exercise book back under Luc's hand. Luc sees the unfinished line and smiles despite himself.

For a moment, every boy has a future he can work toward.

ACT II — THE WORD THE STREET TELLS | 1:34–3:24

INT. CLASSROOM / CORRIDOR — CONTINUOUS | 1:34–1:56

An empty corridor. We hear the word before a person is visible.

VOICE OUTSIDE: Thief!

A pencil stops. Zino turns first. Gideon watches the other students' reactions. Luc keeps his hand on the page.

LUC: Make we leave am.

Zino does not answer. Students pass the doorway. He gets up. Gideon takes his bag; Luc follows the two people he knows into a noise none of them understands yet.

EXT. SCHOOL GATE / ROAD — CONTINUOUS | 1:56–2:46

The first clear wide shot fixes the geography. A crowd grows on the left of frame. The lit school gate is behind/right. The boys stop at the edge. The way back remains visible.

Voices repeat the accusation. They do not agree on an explanation. The camera never supplies the missing theft.

Luc hesitates. Adults cross in front of the boys. Zino catches Luc's sleeve rather than pushing ahead.

ZINO: Stay here.

Gideon is still beside them, olive shirt visible against the gate light. His camera stays in its bag. He is a boy assessing danger, not a witness collecting a future thriller clue.

Adult shoulders fill the foreground. A gap opens, then closes. Their curiosity has become something harder to put down.

EXT. ROAD — WITNESS VIEW — CONTINUOUS | 2:46–3:24

Through a narrow sightline, a restrained adult raises one hand. The movement is a plea, not evidence. A blow lands. The crowd can overpower him; that is the only certainty the boys have.

Zino's mouth starts a word. It never becomes a story.

The material violence registers directly: the tires, the assault, the attack turning into fire. No slow-motion preparation, ornamental montage or hero angle. The adult remains anonymous; the author has not supplied his identity, guilt or outcome for this composite.

The scream carries across the cut. Heat and light reach the boys. No score gives the moment a release. Nobody in the frame has become the invented man on the roof.

ACT III — THE TRUTH HE CAN BEGIN | 3:24–5:00

EXT. ROAD / SCHOOL GATE — CONTINUOUS | 3:24–4:13

The roofline is empty. No gold, no silhouette, no quiet answer from Grand. Only ordinary darkness above people doing something irreversible.

Zino looks at Luc, then Gideon. He knows where both are.

ZINO: Luc. Gideon. We go.

He takes them together toward the gate already established behind/right. They are not chased. They have not discovered a secret escape or abandoned a rescue the screenplay pretended they could accomplish. They are schoolboys getting one another away from a violent crowd.

The street's roar fades behind footsteps. The camera holds long enough for leaving to feel like a decision, not an action-film triumph.

EXT. FIANGO COMPOUND — WELL — NIGHT | 4:13–5:00

The familiar mango tree. A lit doorway. A neighbour still doing ordinary work. Zino reaches the drawn bucket beside the well and tries to lift fresh drinking water to his mouth. His cupped hands shake and spill; they match the opening precisely. Now the audience knows their cause. He does not wash smoke, dirt or an invented injury into the drinking-water well.

Mother sets aside marked exercise books. She stays at his level and gives him room to answer.

MOTHER (English): What happened?

He attempts the smile first, then lifts the hand that used to bring a whole imagined man into being.

ZINO (English): Grand—

His hand falls. No picture appears. He looks at her.

ZINO (English): There was a man.

Hold his face. For the first time in the pilot, he has begun a story he cannot make end differently.

BLACK. TITLE in the final two seconds: GRAND-CHUKUCHUKU.

One unresolved note may enter after black. No outside knock, secret pursuer or promise of an invented conspiracy. The next episode owes the audience the rest of his account and his mother's response.

Continuity and source notes

- Confirmed foundations: Fiango well/mango compound; street football and slipper goals; Zino's invented Grand; friendship with Gideon and Luc; maths help; Luc's small Bible; Gideon's camera from secondary school onward; Professional School's vocational function and night access; Zino's account of witnessing multiple jungle-justice incidents during secondary school; Mother's primary-school teaching.

- The incident is a **proposed secondary-school composite**. Approximate age fourteen / 2004, exact reactions, friends' presence, route, dialogue and home response are constructed, not recorded testimony. The author may correct placement without changing the real foundation.

- Gideon's camera is absent in the ten-year-old passage as a conservative design choice. At fourteen, it stays closed: there is no fabricated evidence photograph.

- Age-ten secondary-school entry must not inherit the confirmed 1999 primary-fee exclusion. No fee scene appears here.

- Pidgin among friends; English in the home. The opening is the same moment revisited after its cause, not two separate visits.

- The drawings are eighteen keyframes supporting a thirty-six-shot edit. Extra acting poses, reverse coverage, recordings and movement still require an animatic. The source images are not final character turnarounds or finished animation.

- This pilot condenses later Chapter One material as a standalone introduction. The sixty-episode season remains an expansion source; the rejected v1 pilot and its music cue plan are superseded.